Finger Food

By Nina Shengold

A commercial photographer's studio, minimally indicated by a standing flood lamp focused on one end of a long table. The lit end is elegantly set with a lace tablecloth, cut crystal wineglass and bottle of wine. The rest of the table is tacky and bare. There's a canvas director's chair and an empty carton, a telephone, Denny's camera equipment.

. .

Lights up on Denny, staring intently at the wine-bottle set-up. He starts making adjustments, moving the glass, turning the bottle: an artist at work. Perfection. He glares at the door, annoyed. Strides to the phone and dials.

DENNY: Mitchell? Denny. My talent is late again. . . . Runs in her what? I'm not shooting her panty hose. . . . Studio Six, Mitchell . . . No, not deodorant, Beaujolais! . . . Yeah, well she just better shake it, there's Reddi-whip coming at quarter past four! *(He hangs up and returns to his set-up. Turns on the flood lamp. Smiles. Holds one hand next to the wineglass and looks through his camera, rehearsing the shot.)* Oh, baby. *(He steps back for more distance and tries it again.)* Gorgeous. *(He steps back again and finds that he's too far away now to reach the glass. He tries anyway, stretching one arm toward the glass, leaning back with his camera. It looks ridiculous and it doesn't work.)* Damn. *(Sudden brainstorm. He rips off one shoe and sticks his bare foot on the table, gripping the glass with his toes. He picks up the camera and says to his foot:)* Love ya. You're beautiful.

INTRODUCTION

Actress: Remember that Seinfeld episode where George became a hand model? It wasn't entirely fiction--there are such things as hand models and they can make loads of money. There are models for practically every body part, each with their own rigorous requirements. But the money's in hands. Being a hand model requires Precise, graceful movements … breaking a cookie just so … pouring ketchup on a hot dog … And let's not even talk about Finger Food by Nina Shengold

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(Mona rushes in, breathless. She is simply but prettily dressed and wears orange rubber dishwashing gloves. She carries a model's loose-leaf book. Denny jumps up and runs to her.)

DENNY: Carla!

MONA: Darling!

DENNY: *(embraces her, kisses both cheeks, then draws back)* You're not Carla.

MONA: No, I'm . . .

DENNY: I asked them for Carla. The hand model.

MONA: Then... you don't know?

DENNY: I have to have Carla.

MONA: Oh heaven. I thought they had told you. The agency.

DENNY: What happened?

MONA: *(crosses herself with rubber gloves)* She was in . .. She had Carla-a terrible accident. An elevator door.

DENNY: No! Is she all right?

MONA: She was maimed! She broke two of her nails! The thumb and the index! Oh god. I have nightmares. *(She covers her face with her gloves.)*

DENNY: SO the agency sent you instead?

MONA: *(Lowers her hands. He's so insensitive. Glacial)* I'm her understudy.

DENNY: I'm not sure I can do it with somebody else.

MONA: Try me.

DENNY: You've done this before?

MONA: Hundreds of times.

DENNY: A hand job.

MONA: I live for it.

DENNY: I've never seen you.

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MONA: My face, perhaps. No. *(Touches a glove.)* May I hang up my things? *(Denny grabs the carton from under the table and drops it contemptuously in front of her. Mona looks at it. Looks at him. Then she pulls off one rubber glove, finger by finger, like a stripper. He watches, transfixed. Underneath she is wearing a lacy black fingerless glove and crimson nail polish. Denny moans. Mona smiles. She drops the glove into the box and takes off the second, finger by finger.)*

MONA: My name-*(Drops the second glove.)*-is Mona.

DENNY: Urn... Uhhhh . . . huh. Ah. Denny.

MONA: Denny. *(She touches his face. His eyes follow her fingers.)*

DENNY: I love what you're wearing.

MONA: Thank you.

DENNY: You, ah, only do hands?

MONA: I went to the elbows once. Laundry soap. It was awful. I felt so cheap.

DENNY: *(rhapsodic):* Just hands.

MONA: I've brought my portfolio. Will there be makeup?

DENNY: I... I have to see. . . .

MONA: Pictures first. *(She indicates with a graceful, game-show assistant gesture that Denny should sit.)*

DENNY: Pictures. Yes. *(He sits. Mona stands over his shoulder and guides him through the book. We do not see the pictures described.)*

MONA: Most of these are production stills from my video spots. Cold cream. Grape jelly. Men's shirts.

DENNY: Collar-smoothing. Oh Christ. Very nice.

MONA: *(turning the page)* Dishwashing liquid. Which is the coed and which is the 62-year-old grandmother? Neither! They're me! They're both me!!!

DENNY: No!

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MONA: *(nods proudly)* I love doing character work. I studied that grandmother. I'm very Method. *(Turns another page. Breathless.)* Oh. This was my favorite job ever. Chocolate creme devil's food-*(She breaks off, staring.)* Denny. Your toes are nude.

DENNY: *(Looks. They are.)* Yes, well, I . . .

MONA: Denny, they're stunning!!! *(She crouches and pets his toes.)* Oh, Denny. *(Grabs his right hand.) God*. You have wonderful digits.

DENNY: I do?

MONA: Have you ever modeled? You could, you know. You have incredible cuticles.

DENNY: Thank you.

MONA: Your palms. . . Your knuckle hair. . .

DENNY: *(impassioned)* Mona... *(Their hands twine. They look at each other meltingly. Mona drops his hand suddenly, embarrassed. All business. Back to the model book.)*

MONA: Nail polish. Not my best finger.

DENNY: *(turns the next page, reacts with surprise)* Who's that?

MONA: My teacher. Giancarlo. He taught me to grasp. To find the caress in it. *(in a sensuous Italian accent.)* "You must never just reach for a thing. You must yearn for it. Grasp, never grab." *(Wistful.)* Giancarlo had knuckles like Brussel sprouts. Those who can't do. . . . He ran off with a thigh model.

DENNY: You were in love with him.

MONA: He was a genius. He taught Carol Merrill on Let's Make a Deal. *(She does a game-show display gesture.)* Door Number One.. .

DENNY: *(grabs her hand)* You're unbelievable!

MONA: Where can I change?

DENNY: *(stalking her)* Mona, I'm a professional.

MONA: I'm a professional.

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DENNY: Trust me.

MONA: I trust you.

DENNY: This is not smut. This is advertising.

MONA: Stop clutching!

DENNY: *(drops her hand, pulls himself together)* And if you'll excuse me, I need to set up.

MONA: I need to warm up. Excuse me. *(Denny makes an elaborate show of busying himself with wine props and light meter. Mona turns her back to him, peels off her lace gloves, and stretches her fingers. Denny stares as she runs through a series of silly-looking finger exercises, the last few suggesting a cat. Petting, smoothing. Maybe a couple stray mews. Then she applauds herself) (murmurs in Giancarlo's accent)* Brava. Brava, mia Mona! *(stands, very composed and serene)* Where's the cat?

DENNY: Cat?

MONA: Will you want petting or filling the kitty dish?

DENNY: Mona, we're doing a wine ad.

MONA: What? They told me tuna fish Friskies.

DENNY: Beaujolais.

MONA: But the agency told me . . .

DENNY: They're wrong.

MONA: *(starting to panic)* Oh my god. Wine? I have to rethink this. My whole preparation was tuna. Oh, Denny. Oh! This is so sudden!

DENNY: What's wrong?

MONA: Tension. Look at this tension. *(She holds up her claw like hands.) .*

DENNY: Here, let me rub them.

MONA: NO! Wine. Think of wine. *(Drumming her fingers.)* You asked them for Carla. I should have realized. Carla would never do cat food. She doesn't have to do cat

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food. Cheap trash like me does the cat food while Carla does Beaujolais! *(She bites on her thumbnail.)*

DENNY: Mona! Don't do it!!!

MONA: *(realizing, in horror)* Oh god! I knew it! I knew this would happen. That's why I'll never be one of the greats. I'm such a neurotic!

DENNY: You're not.

MONA: You don't know. Denny, I was a nail biter! Mom used to soak them in Lysol. I'd bite them and vomit. And that's not the worst of it! I sucked my thumb!

DENNY: Lots of kids do that.

MONA: Until I was twenty! I sleep in a straitjacket. I just can't trust myself. *(About to bite her nails again, she lets out a cry of despair. Runs to the chair and sits on her hands, rocking back and forth.)* Giancarlo, he warned me. He told me, "Carissima, you got the hands, but you don't got the temperament. I could make you a star, but you wacko!" Oh, Denny! *(She breaks down in tears. Denny reaches to comfort her.)* DON'T lay a finger! Hands OFF!

DENNY: You misunderstand, Mona. I'm a professional.

MONA: I'm a professional.

DENNY: Steel. Like a doctor. I promise you, flesh leaves me cold. Flawless skin and warm naked tapering fingers are nothing. Color and form. Raw material. Meaningless.

MONA: Meaningless??

DENNY: I didn't mean meaningless.

MONA: *(incensed)* Meaningless? Look at this, buster! *(She thrusts out a hand.)* This is the species, right here. Evolution! Opposable thumb! Scratch that and it's monkeyville!

DENNY: I didn't

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MONA: Where would we be without hands? No applause, Denny! No backrubs! No volleyball! Think of great art. The Creation. E.T.! *(She demonstrates Michelangelo's pose.)*

DENNY: Mona, please. . .

MONA: You think this just happened? I worked for this, buddy! I started out slapping men's faces on soap opera! Packets I ripped! I ripped packets! I modeled for aerosol roach sprays you see on the subway! In Spanish! And after all that I went home and did dishes!

DENNY: Hey, I've been there, too, lady. I didn't start out shooting Beaujolais, nosirreebob. They used to give me the ugly foods. Liverwurst. Cheez Whiz. Gefiite fish. I've had to shoot foods that make pigs anorexic!

MONA: You only shoot food?

DENNY: We've got our specialties too, you know. Some guys shoot black and white blue jeans. Some guys do nothing but lingerie. Hey, I'm not knocking it. Half-naked girls wearing satin and lace turns them on, that's their business. *(Looks at her.)* Me, I do food. I do food like I'll have you in tears from how good it looks. Bulging ripe melons with dew on their skins like a tropical rainforest. Corn on the cob dripping butter. Napoleons oozing cream. Hot. . . apple. . . PIE. A la mode and the ice cream's just trickling down off the crust through those thick, juicy. . .

MONA: Chocolate creme devil's food. . . ?

DENNY: Pudding. Cannolis.

MONA *(rhapsodic)* Just food.

DENNY: If it goes in your mouth, I'm your man.

MONA: You inspire me.

DENNY: Your hands and my lens, kiddo. We could make beautiful ad graphics.

MONA: Get your camera.

DENNY: I'm wearing it.

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MONA: Shoot. *(With a dancerly flourish, she cups her hand under the bowl of the wineglass.)* .

DENNY: *(comes in very close and circles seductively, firing off shot after shot)* Beautiful. Baby. Great palm. Stroke the bowl. Can you give me more knuckle? Perfecto. That's super. A little more flex in the wrist. Honey. Angel. Oh yes.

MONA: *(breathing heavily)* Yes! You're wonderful!

DENNY: Fingers! More fingers! Oh, angel! Oh., damn *(He stops very suddenly.)*

MONA: Keep shooting! Don't stop, Denny! Shoot me!

DENNY: I'm all out of film.

MONA: Hold my hand! Hold me! *(He clasps her hand ardently.)* God yes. You're ruthless. The sweat of your palms. Take me!

DENNY: *(on fire)* Mona! *(He yanks off his camera and moves in to kiss her. She thrusts her hands in front of his face, palms forward. Denny kisses them feverishly, licks her fingers.)*

MONA: *(suddenly pulls one of his hands away)* Your ring! Take your ring off!

DENNY: I can't.

MONA: Take it off, Denny! Do it!

DENNY: It's stuck! *(Mona slaps him. Shocked silence. She clutches her hand.)*

MONA: Oh god. Oh my god. *(Picks up the wineglass and gulps.)*

DENNY: You can't drink that! It's product!

MONA: Tough.

DENNY: Good point. *(Drinks from the bottle. Pause.)*

MONA: I feel so cheap. Put your shoe on.

DENNY: *(Sits in the chair, puts his shoe back on. Looks at her.)* I'm sorry, Mona. I thought you had seen.

MONA: It's a wedding ring?

DENNY: Yes.

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MONA: Married. My god. Every man on this planet is married! Well, tell me this: who are you married to??? Women I meet aren't married! You marry each other? *(She drinks. Calmer.)* Sorry. I live in New York.

DENNY: It's all right.

MONA: Is she a model? Your wife?

DENNY: A photographer.

MONA: What does she shoot?

DENNY: *(Beat. Shamefaced.)* Laundry soap. *(Mona recoils. Impassioned.)* She's nothing like you! She's got dishpan hands!

MONA: *(gathers up her portfolio, gloves)* Goodbye, Denny.

DENNY: Don't go.

MONA: I have to.

DENNY: Please!

MONA: *(turns back)* The Italians wave. . . so. *(She does the traditional "ciao. ")* As if they were holding a bird. Giancarlo. He taught me. *(She blows Denny a kiss on her fingertips, then goes. Denny stands for a moment. He does a small, wistful "ciao.")*

DENNY: *(He turns off the flood lamp and sits, heartbroken. Then he picks up the phone and dials.)* Mitchell? Yeah, Denny. Look, Mitch, I'm not feeling so hot. You think you could cancel the whipped cream? *(The door opens. It's Mona.)*

MONA: *(eyes shining, breathless)* Did you just say. . . whipped cream??

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